

Palak *Ulikaram*

from the kitchen of Noor

A BIG BOWL FOR THE FAMILY • A LAZY, TANGY AFTERNOON DISH

Spinach cooked down with a tangy, garlicky Andhra masala — roasted chilies and coriander ground with tamarind and a whole lot of garlic, then simmered into the greens until the oil comes shining back to the top. Eat it with hot white rice and a spoon of ghee, and don't count the garlic cloves.

a photo of the palak ulikaram goes here ♦

dark, glossy, and ready for rice

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

FOR THE GROUND MASALA

- 1 big onion, roughly chopped
- a whole lot of garlic — a fistful of cloves
- a lime-sized ball of tamarind
- a good handful of dried red chilies
- 2–3 spoons whole coriander seeds (dhania)
- a spoon of cumin (zira)
- salt, to taste

FOR THE TEMPERING & GREENS

- oil, a generous pour
- mustard seeds & cumin (zira)
- chana dal & urad dal, a spoon each
- a sprig of curry leaves
- a pinch of asafoetida (hing)
- red chili powder, to your bravery
- turmeric (haldi), a good pinch
- lots & lots of spinach, finely chopped
- chopped coriander leaves, to finish
- ghee, for serving

Amounts are by feel — start with more garlic and chili than seems wise, then taste as you go.

HOW WE MAKE IT

- 1 **Roast the whole spices.** Lightly dry-sauté the dried red chilies, coriander seeds and cumin in a pan until they smell warm and toasty — just fragrant, don't burn them.
- 2 **Grind the masala.** Into the blender goes the onion, all that garlic, the tamarind, salt and your roasted chilies, coriander and cumin. Blend to a coarse paste — some texture is good.
- 3 **Start the tempering.** Heat a generous pour of oil until hot. Add mustard seeds, cumin, chana dal, urad dal and the curry leaves — let it splutter and the dals turn golden. Add a pinch of asafoetida.
- 4 **Fry the paste.** Tip in the ground masala and fry for a few minutes, stirring, until it darkens and the oil separates out at the edges.
- 5 **Spice it.** Add red chili powder, turmeric and a little more salt if it needs it. Give it a stir.
- 6 **Cook down the spinach.** Now add lots and lots of chopped spinach. Cook it and cook it and cook it — until all the water has gone and the oil separates again. That's how you know.
- 7 **Finish.** Stir through chopped coriander leaves. Serve with hot white rice and a spoon of ghee.

Amma's note: the whole secret is patience at the end — keep cooking the spinach until the oil comes back. Rushing it leaves it watery. And really, add more garlic than you think.